

gbareader V3.1

Full controls

gbareader is a book reader for the Game Boy Advance. It reads TXT and EPUB books from a Supercard SD card, remembers where you stopped, and shows Latin, Greek, Cyrillic, Japanese, Chinese, Korean and Arabic text.

gbareader is free software (GNU GPL 3.0 or later). Source code: <https://github.com/Xinon232/gbareader>

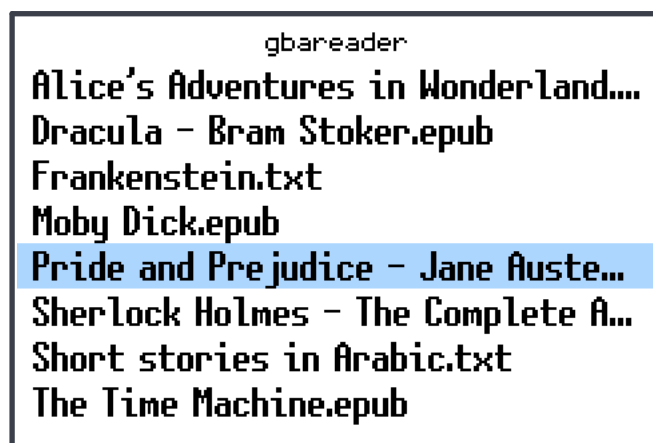
Getting started

- 1 Copy **gbareader.gba** to your SD card and start it from your Supercard loader.
- 2 Put your books in the folder **/gbareader** on the card: UTF-8 **.txt** files and **.epub** files. You can also leave them anywhere on the card and import them later with **Start**.
- 3 Start gbareader. Your books are listed right away, with the cursor on the book you read last.

Buttons at a glance

Where	Button	What it does
Book list	Up / Down	Move. Hold to scroll. At the first or last book, a new press jumps to the other end.
Book list	Left / Right	One page (eight books) back or forward.
Book list	A	Open the book.
Book list	Start	Import books from anywhere on the card.
Book list	Select	Settings.
Reading	A or Right	Next page.
Reading	B or Left	Previous page.
Reading	Start	Save your position.
Reading	hold Up	Turn page turning with L / R on or off.
Reading	Select	Settings (and the way back to the book list).
Settings	Up / Down	Choose a row.
Settings	Left / Right or A	Change the value, or open the row.
Settings	B	Close Settings.
Import	A	Open a folder, or choose a book.
Import	B	Up one folder; from the top, back to the book list.
About	Left / Right	Turn pages. B goes back.

The book list



All TXT and EPUB files in **/gbareader** are listed, eight at a time, in the order they are stored on the card. The selected book has a light blue bar; a long name scrolls so you can read all of it. There is no limit on the number of books.

Reading

Chapter 1

It is a truth universally
acknowledged, that a single man
in possession of a good fortune,
must be in want of a wife.

However little known the
feelings or views of such a man

- Turn pages with **A / Right** (forward) and **B / Left** (back).
- Press **Start** to save your position. The screen shows **save...** and then **Saved**. Turning pages does not save by itself.
- Hold **Up** alone for about a second to turn page turning with **L** (back) and **R** (forward) on or off. **L+R: On** or **L+R: Off** appears for a moment. gbareader remembers your choice.
- Press **Select** for Settings.

If you go back right after a jump, the screen may show **Loading back...** for a moment while earlier pages are prepared.

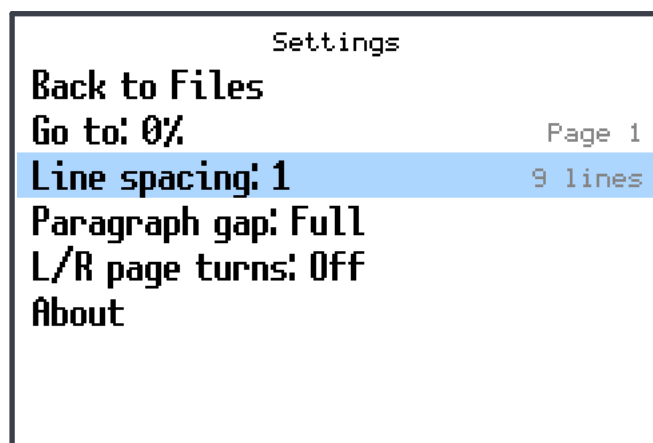
كان يا ما كان في قديم الزمان رجل يحب
القراءة كثيرا.

كل مساء كان يجلس في حديقته الصغيرة تحت
شجرة الزيتون ويفتح كتابا جديدا.

كان يقرأ حتى تغيب الشمس ثم يحمل كتابه
إلى البيت ويكمل القراءة على ضوء الصباح.

Arabic is shown right to left with joined letters. gbareader checks the page a book opens on: if it contains Arabic, Arabic display is switched on for that book and remembered. If the Arabic only starts later in a book, save on a page with Arabic text (**Start**) and open the book again.

Settings

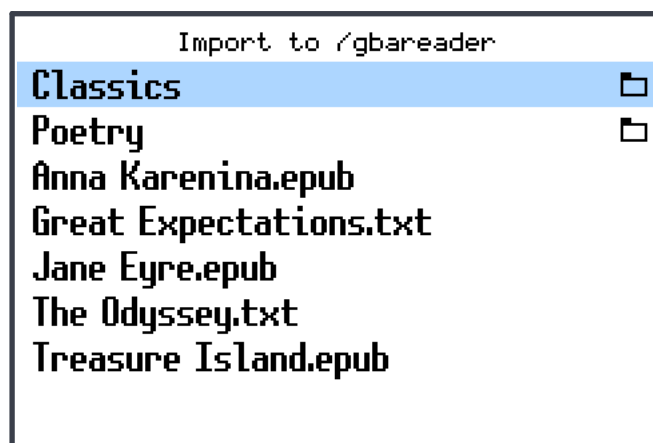


Press **Select** to open Settings, from the book list or while reading. The rows:

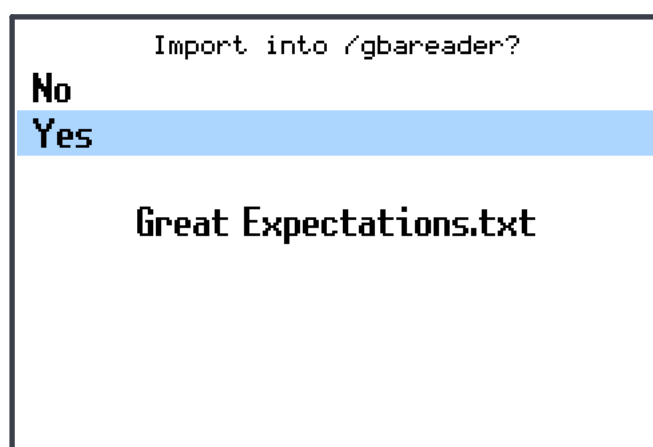
- **Back to Files:** close the book and return to the book list (only while reading). If the page you are on is not the one you saved last, the row asks **Continue without saving?** first: **A** leaves without saving, **B** keeps the book open.
- **Go to:** jump to a percentage of the book (only while reading). **Left / Right** change it by 1% (hold to keep going), **L / R** by 10%. **A** jumps at once; closing Settings also jumps. On the right you see the current page number (**Page about ...** while it is still being counted).
- **Line spacing:** 0 to 4 pixels between lines. On the right: how many lines fit on a page.
- **Paragraph gap:** None, Small, Half or Full line between paragraphs.
- **L/R page turns:** On or Off. Same as holding **Up** while reading.
- **About:** version, contact, the most important controls, and the credits.

B, **Select** or **Start** close Settings. Your settings apply to every book and are saved on the card.

Importing books



On the book list, press **Start**. The screen **Import to /gbareader** shows the folders (with a folder symbol) and the TXT and EPUB books of the SD card, starting at the top of the card.



Choose a book with **A**. gbareader asks **Import into /gbareader?**; **No** is selected first. Choose **Yes** to copy the book. The book list then appears with the new book selected and the message **Imported**.

- The original file stays where it was; gbareader makes a copy.
- If **/gbareader** does not exist yet, it is created.
- A book with the same name is never overwritten: you see **Already in /gbareader**.
- If the copy fails, no half-copied file is left behind.

Files on the card

- Each book gets a small companion file next to it, for example **Title.epub.sav** for **Title.epub**. It holds your position, earlier pages for going back, the Arabic setting and, for EPUB books, a prepared copy of the text. Your book files are never changed.
- **SETTINGS0.DAT** and **SETTINGS1.DAT** in **/gbareader** hold your settings and the last book you opened.
- When you rename or move a book on a computer, rename or move its **.sav** file with it. Deleting a **.sav** file only loses the saved position; the book still opens.
- An EPUB can show **Preparing cache...** the first time you open it. This happens once.

Messages

Message	Meaning
Saved	Your position and settings were saved.
Position save failed	The position could not be saved. Stay in the book and press Start again.
Settings save failed	Your settings could not be saved yet. They are tried again on the next save.
Both saves failed	Neither could be saved. Check the card and try Start again.
No books found	/gbareader is empty or missing. Press Start to import books.
No SD card	The card could not be read.
Settings recovered	One copy of the settings was damaged; the other one was used.
Settings load failed	The settings could not be read; defaults are used.

Good to know

- EPUB books are shown as text only: no pictures, special layouts or DRM-protected books.
- TXT files must be UTF-8 (plain ASCII is fine too).
- Books must be directly in **/gbareader**; subfolders there are not listed. To save positions, a book's file name can be at most 251 bytes long.
- Do not switch off the GBA or remove the card while **save...**, **Preparing cache...** or **Importing...** is shown. Keep a backup of your books.
- This version has not been tested on every card and Supercard model yet.

Credits and licenses

Made by Halim Jarrar, (C) 2026. Website: <https://halimj.itch.io> - Contact: gba@halim-jarrar.de

gbareader is free software under the GNU GPL v3 or later. Source code:

<https://github.com/Xinon232/gbareader>

gbareader builds on the work of others:

Part	Made by	License
SuperFW font rendering and font packs	David Guillen Fandos	GPL v3 or later. The UNSCII-based pack includes GNU Unifont and public-domain Fixedsys Excelsior glyphs.
Ghoulam Arabic pixel font	(C) 2025 Imad AlFil / mloukhiyye	CC BY 4.0
Butano game engine	Gustavo Valiente	zlib
FatFs	ChaN	permissive license
The decompression part of miniz	Rich Geldreich and others	MIT

The Ghoulam font was converted to fit the Game Boy screen. This conversion is not endorsed by the font's author. Font: <https://mloukhiyye.itch.io/ghoulam-arabic-pixel-art-font-version-1> - License: <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>

Butano: <https://github.com/GValiente/butano>

The credits are also shown in the app under Settings > About.